

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

Born into a poor family, married at 14 to a man who was old enough to be her father, she became a mother at 15 and a widow at 16. Growing up without electricity or a concrete roof, she had to give up her studies as her father could not bear the cost but realised her dreams through fearless commitment. It may appear

an unfamiliar story, but not so for Bihar's backwaters, where 35-year-old Veena Devi is serving her second-term as *mukhiya* (panchayat chief) of the Loharpur Panchayat of Nawada district. Winning from an unreserved seat, she was one of the four women village heads who shared the dais with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and UPA chairperson Sonia Gandhi at a national convention of Panchayati Raj last year.

The journey has not been easy for her. She had to face all kinds of adversities—from openly sceptical men to fake murder charges. "When I first contested the Panchayat elections in 2000, the men in my village laughed at me. They used to ask me who did I think I was, Indira Gandhi?" she recalls, smiling.

Veena had to fight against almost everyone, including hostile in-laws, discouraging relatives and a local strongman, who was running for the post in

the crime-ridden and caste-polarised district. The men in her village may have shunned her, but Veena had a strategy to overcome the odds. "I visited every household and convinced the

power POINT

★ Veena Devi,

Project Women empowerment in Bihar's caste polarised and crime-ridden Nawada district

Can-do Icon Sonia Gandhi for determination and confidence to move

10 women candidates won seats, out of 20 who contested the Bihar Panchayat Elections in 2000

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I visited every woman in my village and convinced the woman folk that I am the best choice for them, as I am one of them.

VEENA DEVI, Mukhiya

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